

Kagu and sunbittern

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Eurypygiformes
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	2

These two birds have similar foraging behavior and a dramatic spread-wing courtship display, most colorful in the sunbittern. Both species also have powder down, insulating them in the extremes of wet tropical forest climates. Such down is shared by herons and mesites, but not cranes. Although visually so different, the two are clearly more closely related to each other than to any other group.

SUNBITTERN
Beautifully camouflaged at rest, the sunbittern bursts into color when displaying its wings.



Rhynochetos jubatus

Kagu



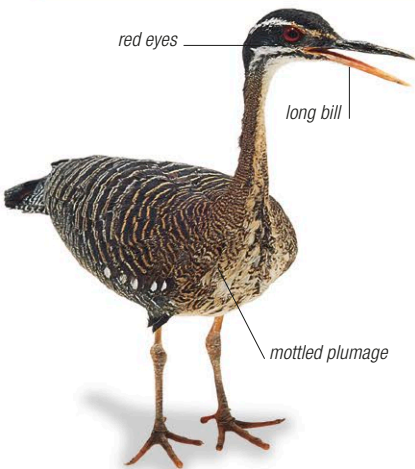
Length	21½ in (55 cm)
Weight	32 oz (900 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Endangered

Location New Caledonia



With its stocky body, weak wings, and large, erectile crest, the kagu is a typical island species that has evolved a distinctive appearance and way of life. It lives on the ground, and often stands motionless on one leg, watching and listening for prey. If it strikes and misses,

it will use its bill to dig out the prey; unique flaps of skin over the nostrils keep out debris while the kagu forages in soil. When threatened, it raises its shaggy crest and spreads its wings to expose the shieldlike pattern on its flight feathers.



Eurypyga helias

Sunbittern



Length	17–19 in (43–48 cm)
Weight	7 oz (200 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern

Location Central America, N. South America



An inhabitant of shady rainforest streambanks, the sunbittern is a wary bird that stalks its prey slowly and

deliberately, then quickly stabs it with its slender bill. If threatened when in the nest, it moves its neck backward and forward, and hisses like a snake. At other times, it will turn to face its predator, and fan its tail and spread its wings (like the kagu, right) to expose large, eyelike patches. The large “eyes” and the spread of the wings and tail make the sunbittern look very big and imposing. Its mottled, cryptic plumage is soft, enabling it to fly silently. A solitary bird, even paired adults are seldom seen together.

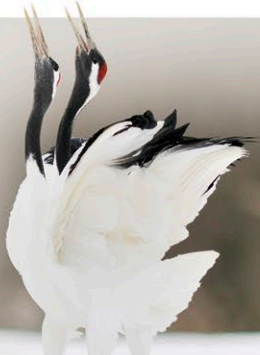
Rails, cranes, and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Gruiformes
FAMILIES	6
SPECIES	189

Rails are small to medium-sized, mostly waterside birds, typically keeping well hidden in dense vegetation. Cranes are much larger heron- or storklike birds of more open habitats. Some other groups, including finfoots, trumpeters, and the limpkin, are included in the order, based largely on DNA analysis, creating a large and diverse group.

RED-CROWNED CRANE

Cranes' dramatic courtship displays involve rhythmic “dancing” actions, deep bows, and short leaps from the ground, and synchronized, fluid movements of the head and neck.



Anthropoides paradiseus

Blue crane



Length	39–43 in (100–110 cm)
Weight	9–13 lb (4–6.2 kg)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Vulnerable

Location S. Africa



This arid country crane has long wing plumes that appear like a tail from a distance. It is restricted to South Africa (where it is the national bird) and Namibia. Although it may gather into large flocks outside the breeding season, overall numbers of this species have sharply declined



since the 1970s. This has been caused by factors such as insecticide poisoning on agricultural land and conversion of its grassland habitat into forest; birds are also killed by power-line collisions. Conservation programs are now assisting this species.

Grus grus

Common crane



Length	4 ft (1.2 m)
Weight	11–13 lb (5–6 kg)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Migrant
Status	Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, N. Africa



Like other members of its family, the common crane is a large, elegant bird, with a long bill and long legs. Gray, with a black head and neck, it has a white stripe down the nape, and a red spot on the crown. It gives a loud, trumpeting call, the sound being amplified by an enlarged windpipe that is fused with the breastbone.

